Dingli Wang

Teaching Statement

Department of Economics, University of California, Riverside
dwang177@ucr.edu | dingliwang.github.io

My goal is for students to understand what a method is doing and why, not only how to apply a formula. I usually teach in the same order: start with the economic or statistical question, work through a simple example, introduce the formal result, and then return to interpretation. At UC Riverside, I have been the instructor of record for three separate courses: *International Trade*; *Trade, Globalization, and Development*; and *Mini-Statistics*, an intensive statistics course for incoming Economics Ph.D. students. I have also been a teaching assistant for undergraduate microeconomics, macroeconomics, statistics, and econometrics, and for the Ph.D. econometrics sequence. In 2026, I received UCR's Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award.

In quantitative courses, I try to make the logic behind a formula visible before asking students to use it. In *Mini-Statistics*, for example, I introduce transformations of random variables with the simple case $Y = 2X$. The values of the variable spread out by a factor of two, but the probability assigned to corresponding intervals does not change, so the density must fall by a factor of two. Once that point is clear, the inverse derivative in the general density transformation formula has a natural interpretation. I use the same approach in econometrics: before working through an estimator or an asymptotic result, I want students to know what is being estimated, what source of randomness matters, and which assumption supports each step.

In economics courses, I use models to organize a question rather than treat the model as the final answer. In *Trade, Globalization, and Development*, for example, students study why trade can raise aggregate income while affecting workers, industries, and countries differently. I ask them to separate the mechanism in the model, the evidence relevant to that mechanism, and the conclusion the evidence supports. This helps students use economic models to think about policy questions without turning the model into a slogan.

I also want students to use quantitative tools with confidence. In *Statistics for Economics* labs, I guided students through RStudio and Quarto exercises, including working with data, running statistical analyses, and interpreting results. I prepared short video walkthroughs of software steps so students could return to them when working independently. In lab and when reviewing solutions, I focus on what the output means, not only whether the code runs. I use follow-up questions that change a variable or an assumption to see whether students can apply what they have learned.

I am prepared to teach undergraduate statistics, econometrics, introductory economics, international trade, and development, as well as graduate statistics preparation and econometrics. My research also prepares me to teach electives in time series, forecasting, financial econometrics, and machine learning for economists. In a forecasting course, for example, I would ask students to compare simple averages with estimated combinations and evaluate their accuracy on data not used to fit the models. Students would learn not only how to estimate a model, but also how to judge whether a more complicated method improves a forecast. I want them to leave my courses able to work with data, evaluate evidence, and explain their conclusions clearly.